

THE HUMAN COST OF PRECISION

VAR delivered accuracy at the World Cup, but also **reignited** football's oldest debate: when does precision become overreach?

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The FIFA World Cup and Video Assistant Referee (VAR) have a long history. The 2018 World Cup in Russia was many football fans' first introduction to video review in the game, and since then, it has become a staple of football's biggest moments.

Coming into the 2026 edition, VAR was given an expanded mandate, including correcting corners awarded incorrectly and spotting cases of time-wasting from dead-ball situations. Hand in hand with this came concerns that VAR might begin to 're-referee' games in real time, while FIFA, for its part, encouraged referees to adopt a light-touch approach when making decisions.

However, 104 matches later, that has not been the case. Instead, the invisible hand of VAR has become more conspicuous than ever, often having defining implications for teams.

Where VAR got it right

It is worth noting that several of the rule changes integrated into the VAR protocols for the World Cup worked well.

A good example is the new rule surrounding players covering their mouths while speaking to opponents on the pitch. It was introduced with support from FIFA President Gianni Infantino after an incident in the Champions League where Benfica's Gianluca Prestianni

was given a ban for using discriminatory language against Real Madrid's Vinicius Junior while doing so.

At the World Cup, referees were given a directive that players seen covering their mouths while talking to opponents in confrontational situations should be shown a direct card, and Paraguay's Miguel Almiron and Ecuador's Piero Hincapié both fell foul of it.

Similarly positive was the continued use of the semi-automated offside system, designed to expedite the process of determining offsides. While it had heartbreaking consequences for Iran, which was eliminated after a late winner was ruled out, it succeeded in cutting down the time spent adjudicating close calls.

Wading through the grey area

However, VAR has always been criticised for its handling of subjective decisions, and the 2026 World Cup proved no different.

Few teams understand this quite like Croatia, which saw its